young Akbar a few years earlier, in 1560, and performing the kornish while seated on his horse. The punishment was even more humiliating for one Lashkar Khan who appeared in court visibly drunk in the daytime. Akbar had him tied to a horse's tail and paraded through the town, and then sent to prison, to serve as a lesson to 'himself and to others'.

Even when the amirs were away from court, Akbar kept a very close watch on his men. They were only ever allowed to be in their jagirs, or in the areas they were administering, and contact was maintained at all times, through farmans, messengers, and other orders and appointments. If Akbar wanted to particularly distinguish one of his men, he might send a khillat, a sumptuous robe of honour. In its most extravagant form, a khillat could include a long coat, a gown, turban, jacket, shawl, patka, payjama, qaba, and scarf. When receiving such a mark of favour, the chosen amir, wherever he was in the empire, had to prostrate himself in submission before the khillat, as if in the presence of the emperor himself.

Every subah within the Mughal territory also had a miniature replica of the imperial government, with a governor, diwan, bakshi, sadr etc., who had duties similar to their imperial counterparts at the centre. The governor reported directly to the emperor while the provincial diwans communicated through the imperial diwan.

The far corners of the empire were also linked by a network of intelligence, through 'experienced spies and traders' who were dispatched to blend in with the local population and collect information. Spies were likewise sent abroad, in anticipation of military excursions, to map roads and terrains. When the army was on the move, spies were sent to infiltrate the enemy troops, posing as soldiers. Itinerant merchants and holy men were also deployed, as they could travel widely while not raising any suspicion. All this information was then written up by waqia nevis, or news writers, assigned around the country and dispatched to the court.

Messages between the court and the provinces were relayed extremely rapidly, either by carrier pigeons or by fleet-footed runners, spurred on by opium and bhang. These runners would train with lead weights on their feet to make them swifter. Since the runners needed to use the roads even by night, 'at every 500 paces small pieces of stones are fixed, which the inhabitants of the nearest villages are bound to whiten from time to time so that the letter carriers can distinguish the road on dark and rainy nights'.